Amanda and the Wounded Birds

By Colby Rodowsky

AMANDA: **(Pg 78-86)** It's not that my mother doesn't understand, because she does. In fact, she understands so well that half the time she goes around with a glazed look in her eyes and forgets to get her hair cut and that we're almost out of toilet paper. She makes her living understanding. You see, my mother is Emma Hart, a psychotherapist, which means that she tries to help people who call in to her on the radio; find ways of dealing with their problems.

INTRODUCTION

Many daughters of emotionally absent mothers spend their entire childhood trying to win their mom's love and approval instead of focusing on themselves. As a result, they grow up not knowing who they are, what they want from life, or even what they enjoy doing. They might feel empty, alone, and aimless, which often leads to anxiety or depression. Can Amanda break through to her mom and have the courage to ask for what she needs, or will her mom's focus forever be tied to her patients rather than her daughter?

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AMANDA: I never will forget that first show. I mean, there was my mother's voice coming out of our kitchen radio, sounding slightly frantic and giving those first callers more than they bargained for. It wasn't long before people opened by saying, "I didn't think I'd ever get through to you." After only a month on the air the Emma Hart Show went from one hour to two.

Mom really cared about the people who telephoned her, and almost from the beginning she was calling them her "wounded birds." Not on the air, of course, and never to anyone but me.

MOM: I hope my wounded bird with the abusive husband will get herself into counseling. The wounded bird with those children who walk all over her had better learn to assert herself before it's too late.

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AMANDA: And I learned not to joke around: once I referred to one of her callers as a fractured canary and almost started World War lll.

Mom was busier than she had ever been before, what with traveling and lecturing and doing guest shows from other cities. Sometimes I felt that life was nothing but a revolving door. Mom going out while I was coming in. I know there are some kids who would've thought I was lucky, but the thing about my mother is that she's okay ... And I wanted to see more of her. Besides that, I needed to talk to her. I don't know why, but all of a sudden it seemed that things were piling up around me. No major crises, you understand.

- My friend Terri has a secret crush on my boyfriend Josh. If she does, it would be a disaster, because how could we really be friends anymore? But then again how could Terri and I not be friends?
- Then there's Miss Spellman, my English teacher, who has this really atrocious breath and is forever leaning into people as she reads poetry in class. Imagine somebody breathing garbage fumes on you as she recites - Emily Dickinson lf something doesn't happen soon I may never like poetry again.
- And . . . I was coming out of gym on my way to study hall when Mr. Burnside, the guidance counselor, stopped me and started asking me what my career goals were and had I decided what I wanted to major in in-college. What I said, only politer, was that how did I know what I wanted to major in when **I** didn't even know where I wanted to go to college? Mr. Burnside got a wild look in his eyes and started opening and closing his mouth so that all I could see was a shiny strand of spit running between his top and bottom teeth while he lectured me on how I was going about this whole college thing the wrong way. He said I should come into the guidance office and let him feed me into the computer - well, not me exactly, but stuff like my grades, extra-curricular activities, and whether or not I needed financial aid

MR. BURNSIDE: And what does your mother say? You'll certainly have it easier than anybody else in your class - living with Dr. Emma Hart. *(chuckling)* She'll get right to the Hart of it. Anybody else'd have to call her on the telephone.

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AMANDA: Anybody else'd have to call her on the telephone . . . Why not? Why not? And pretty soon why not? changed to when? I practiced in the shower making my voice huskier than usual and just a little breathless, hoping that it would sound sincere. Once I'd made up my mind to call Dr. Emma Hart, I began to feel like a wounded bird myself, and I was suddenly awfully glad that she cared about them the way she did.

(on the phone) I put the call in just before eleven on the Monday morning of spring vacation. I heard my voice, as if it were coming from somewhere far away, giving my name as Claire ... it's my middle name, and outlining my problem. And all of a sudden, I was talking to my own mother and telling her how I couldn't talk to my mother. . . Dr. Hart let me go on for a while and then she broke in and said that it was important for me to know that my concerns were as real as anybody else's. What I had to do was be really up-front with her and let her know how I felt. Then she suggested that I make a date with my mother for lunch so that I could tell her (Mom) exactly what I'd told her (Dr. Emma Hart).

The only trouble was that as soon as Mom got home that day, I knew it wasn't going to work. She was sort of coming unglued. It had been a bad day.

MOM: Thank heavens you've got it all together.

AMANDA: Talk about guilt. Right away I knew I was going to break rule number one: I wasn't going to be able to be up-front. I couldn't take what was already one rotten week for Mom and dump my problems, which seemed to be getting bigger by the minute, on her. I felt like I was going to explode. By Friday I knew I needed another talk with Dr. Hart.

RECEPTIONIST: Hold on. Dr. Hart will be with you soon.

AMANDA: And there was Dr. Emma Hart again. And suddenly there I was. unloading about how what she had suggested wasn't going to work.

EMMA HART: Why not? Did you try?

AMANDA: Yes - no. *(to audience)* Then I was going on again all about Miss Spellnan, the guidance counselor; and how maybe my best friend had a thing for my boyfriend. **I** said that my mother was swamped, preoccupied, distracted. And then it happened. *(to Emma Hart)* The thing about my mother is that she has all these wounded birds who have really

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important problems, and they take all the time she has. *(to audience)* A silence ballooned up between us and was so loud I couldn't hear anything else. When Mom finally spoke, her voice sounded choked, as if she had swallowed a gumball.

EMMA HART: We've been talking to Claire this morning, who is really Amanda. And one of the things we talk a lot about on this show is saying what you have to say even if that's not always easy. Are you still there, Amanda? *(strangled affirmation from Amanda) If* I know Amanda, she would rather have run away, or hung up, but instead she did something harder. She hung on.

Amanda is my daughter, and it seems we have some things to talk about, so what I'm going to do is to ask my assistant to make a reservation for lunch at the Terrace Garden. If you hurry, Amanda, I'll meet you at 1:30. So we can talk.

AMANDA: And we did: about Miss Spellman, and Terri, and how it's okay not to know now what I want to do with the rest of my life. We talked about saving the whales, and our two weeks at the shore this summer, and how someday we're going to Ireland. About books and movies and the time in fourth grade when I got the chicken pox and Mom caught them from me. And we talked about how we had missed **talking** to each other and what we could do about it. We sat there all afternoon, until the light streaking in the windows changed from yellow to a deep, burning gold and the busboys started setting the tables for dinner.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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